

reveals how your baby is developing and the changes that are occurring in your body. The 280 days, or 40 weeks, of pregnancy are divided into three trimesters, each of which comprises around a third of the pregnancy. Beyond being a simple measure of time, each trimester represents a distinct phase in the development of the baby and in the pregnancy.

The first trimester The definition of the first trimester is given here as weeks 1–12, though you may also see weeks 13 and 14 included elsewhere. This trimester covers the time from the beginning of the menstrual period to the moment of conception, which is usually around two weeks. Because the exact moment of conception is unknown, pregnancy is counted from the one definite date, the beginning of the menstrual cycle. Although technically your pregnancy may not begin until two weeks into your menstrual cycle, these two weeks are very important in helping your body achieve a healthy pregnancy. In this section, we explain day by day the changes that take place in your uterus to prepare it for conception and implantation of the early embryo. There is dietary advice and recommendations from fertility experts to boost your chances of conceiving. The first trimester is a period of extraordinary development, when all your baby's major organs form, and they will grow faster than at any other period in life. A day-by-day account is given of the changes that you and your baby undergo, and advice offered on how to cope with the exhausting changes that occur in early pregnancy. There's also an honest appraisal of the emotional feelings you're likely to experience, reassuring you that negative as well as positive emotions are normal. Practical information on accessing prenatal care and detailed explanations of the choices that are available help you begin to plan your pregnancy and think about your options for the birth.

The second trimester In the second trimester, which is designated as weeks 13–25, your baby's organs mature further and growth continues. This is an exciting time as your body starts to change shape to accommodate your growing baby and you feel your baby move for the first time. However, it is also a time when women can experience symptoms that are often due to quite normal pregnancy changes but that can occasionally indicate a problem. For example, abdominal pain can be due to ligaments being stretched or to constipation; however, it could also indicate a problem with the placenta. Symptoms such as these are discussed at the relevant point in pregnancy, with detailed explanations that will provide reassurance or alert you to the possibility of something more serious that should be brought to the attention of your doctor.

The third trimester In the third trimester, designated as weeks 26–40, your baby continues to grow and mature and, if born early, could survive life outside the uterus. During this time, your body starts to prepare itself for labor. We describe the changes taking place and explain why they occur, as well as providing pointers to what is normal and which symptoms need to be reported to your doctor. Women recount their experiences, and questions that are presented daily to doctors are reproduced to provide a bank of vital knowledge. Practical guidance on all matters, from maternity leave entitlement information to reassurance that having sex won't harm the growing baby, helps you navigate your way through the final weeks of pregnancy.